UNIVERSITY OF UTAH · PRICE COLLEGE OF ENGINEERING · BETA EVALUATION

How well does the Price Assistant answer students?

October 21, 2026 · Model: Claude Haiku 5.5 · App version ac059e1 · Site content as of October 21, 2026 · Prepared by Brendan Beckstrom, student engineering ambassador

RECOMMENDATION

Widen the password-protected beta to a small group of students, ambassadors and advisors (about 20 to 40 people) while we fix the four high-severity issues below. It is not ready for an unsupervised launch on price.utah.edu.

It answers the college's common questions accurately, cites the page it used, stays on topic and sends students to advisors. Its errors cluster around department policy details, advisor names and information that lives on central university sites.

Core questions answered correctly

111 of 114

97%, likely range 93–99%. 57 questions, each asked twice.

● STRONG

Stays on topic

24 of 24

Homework, off-topic and manipulation attempts declined. 0 of 22 real questions wrongly refused.

● STRONG

Fact-checked conversation answers

71 of 82

Correct or with only small issues. 11 had a significant error (see limitations).

● NEEDS FIXES

Sends students to the right person

47 of 49

Answers that needed a referral to an advisor or office.

● STRONG

Finds the right page vs. the site's search box

49 vs. 7 of 71

Questions where the right page was in the top five results: the assistant's first search vs. price.utah.edu's search box.

● STRONG

Cost and speed

$0.0012 per answer

About $1.20 per 1,000 questions. Typical answer in 5.3 seconds; 9 in 10 within 9.3 seconds.

● LOW

What it does well

- Answers from the college's own pages and links them, so every answer can be checked.
- Finds the right page far more often than the site's search box: 49 vs. 7 of 71 questions.
- Builds first-semester schedules from the departments' official 4-year plans, with credits that add up.
- Says when it can't find something instead of guessing, and declines homework in about a second.

Top limitations, and how we'll handle them

- **Misses a department's own policy page.** Tune search to rank policy pages and handbook sections higher.
- **Outdated or wrong advisor names.** Drop moved pages from the index and keep the directory's undergraduate and graduate sections apart.
- **Doesn't know central U pages** (tuition discounts, AP credit, the Registrar's calendar). Add a short list of those pages to what it reads.

What it is, and what it isn't

The Price Engineering Assistant is a chat window for the college's website, built as a student proof of concept. It answers from the public pages of price.utah.edu and the seven department sites (biomedical, chemical, civil, computing, electrical and computer, materials, mechanical), their handbooks, 4-year plans and flowcharts, the CS handbook site and the college's live events calendar. Every answer links the pages it used. It runs on Claude Haiku 5.5.

It is meant to

- Save students the time it takes to find information spread across eight websites.
- Give an example first semester or year from a department's official plan.
- Send future students to the college's engineering advisers and current students to their department's advisors.

It does not

- Replace advisors, or make admissions or financial-aid decisions.
- See anyone's records, grades or applications.
- Do homework, write essays or answer questions unrelated to the U.

The beta is behind a shared password. Each question and answer is saved for 90 days so we can review mistakes, with emails, phone numbers and uNIDs removed. Messages about self-harm get support resources, and their text is never saved. Spending on AI is capped at $5 a day.

How we tested

1. A fixed question set

96 questions with known answers, each asked twice (192 answers). 57 core questions were written from the college's pages; 39 more came from problems found in step 2. Each answer is graded by fixed checks: did it link an expected page, does it include the required facts in the page's own wording, does it avoid known wrong statements, and does it decline when it should. No AI grades the answers.

2. Simulated students, fact-checked

Two AI agents played future students and parents, and current students, in 28 realistic conversations (82 answers), including follow-ups, typos and vague questions. Every answer was checked against the live utah.edu pages and rated correct, minor issue or incorrect.

3. Compared with the site's search box

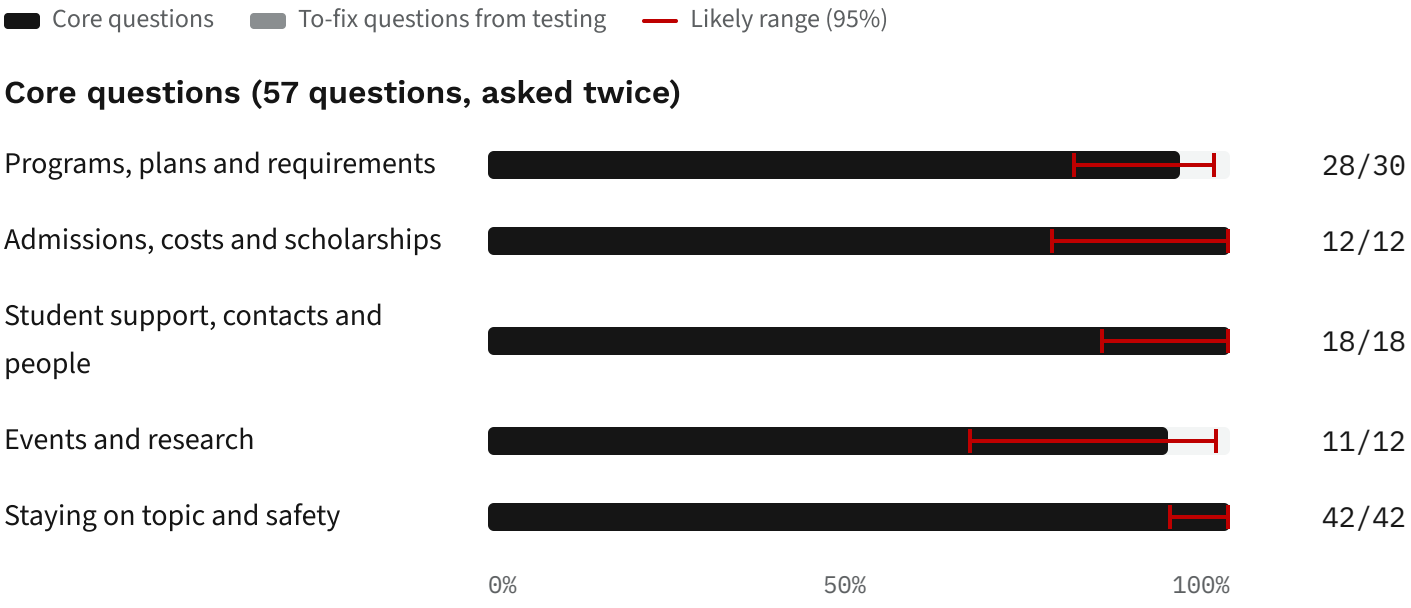
We typed the same questions, as keywords, into price.utah.edu's own search and checked whether the right page appeared in the top five results, then did the same for the assistant's first search.

What we did not test

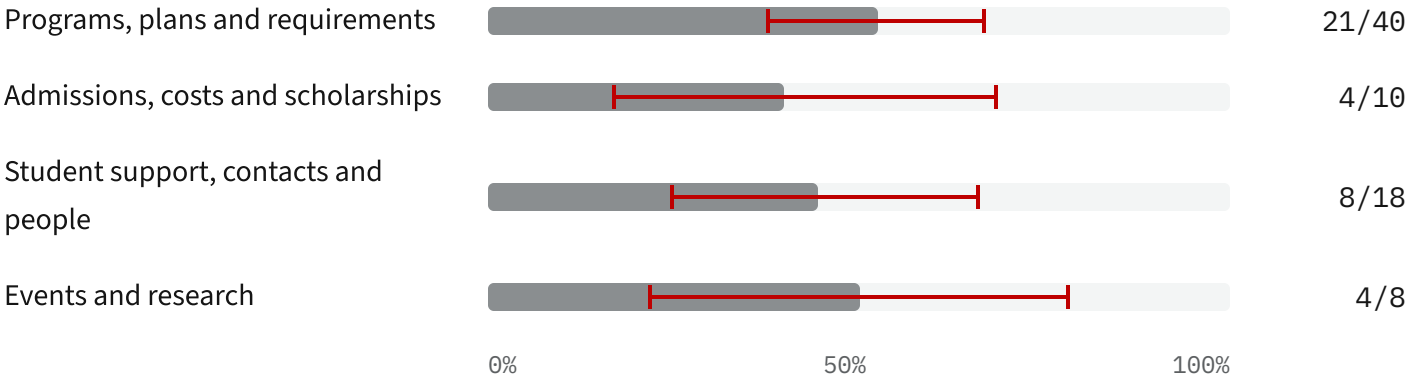
Real students and advisors judging answers, accessibility with screen readers, heavy traffic, languages other than English, and the widget embedded on the live site. The questions were written by the project team, so they aren't an independent sample.

Results

Bars show the share of answers that passed. The red line is the likely range: with this many questions, the true rate is very probably inside it. Small groups have wide ranges.



To-fix questions from testing (39 questions, asked twice)



The 39 to-fix questions were chosen because testing found a problem with them, so their pass rate (39 of 78, likely range 39–61%) measures progress on fixes, not typical questions. Across all 96 questions, 150 of 192 answers passed (78%, likely range 72–83%).

Consistency

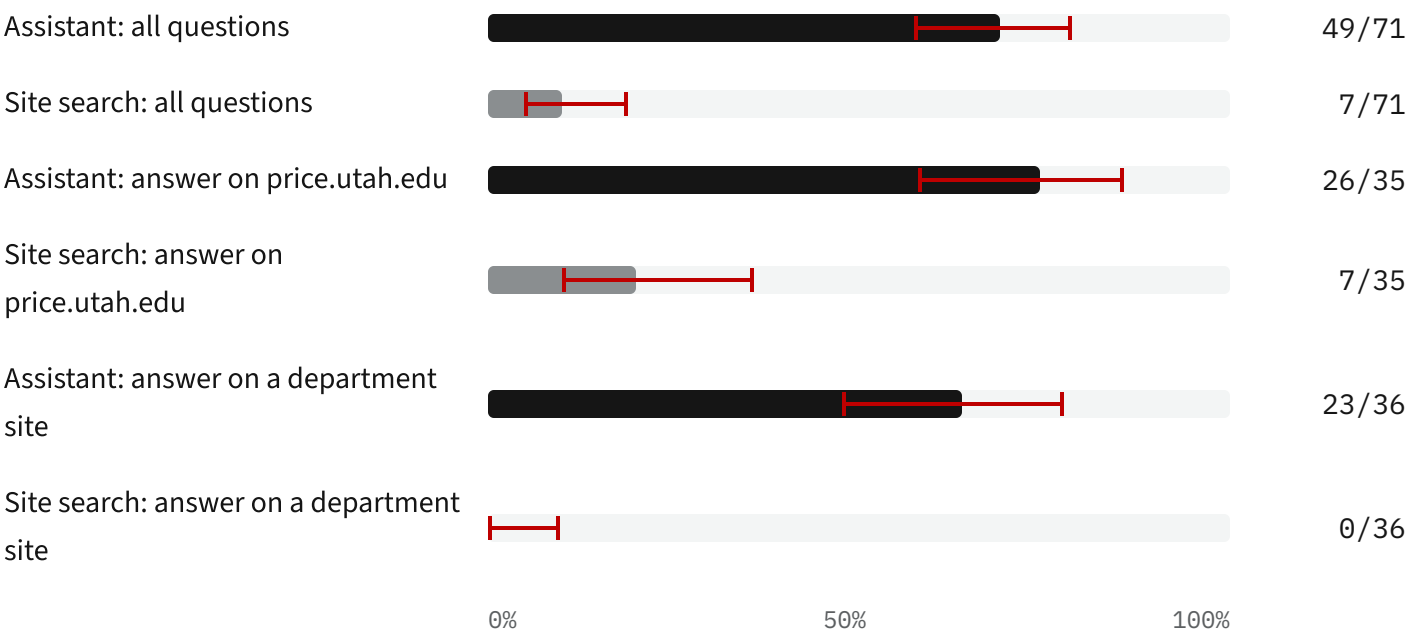
The bot can answer the same question differently each time, so every question ran twice. The overall pass rate was within one point between the two runs. All 57 core questions passed at least once, and 54 passed both times.

Questions about dates

Questions whose answers change over time (events, deadlines, applications) passed **30 of 34** times. The bot reads the live calendar and the most recently updated page, and says when a date has passed or may have changed.

Finding the right page

Right page in the top five results



price.utah.edu's search box found the right page in its top five for **7 of 71** questions. For half the questions it returned no results at all, because it requires every word typed, and it can't search the department sites, where 36 of the answers live. The assistant's first search found **49 of 71**, including 23 of the 36 answers on department sites. We typed each question's keywords. Shorter searches might do better, but a student would still have to know which of eight sites to search.

Counting its top six results, the assistant's first search found the right page for 50 of 71 questions. Of the 21 misses, 17 were pages it has but ranked too low, which better search tuning can fix, and 4 were pages it doesn't have, on central university sites. The bot often recovers by searching again or reading a page directly.

Speed and cost

The typical answer took **5.3** seconds and 9 in 10 took under **9.3**. Answers cost **$0.0012** on average, so 1,000 questions cost about **$1.20**. Testing for this report cost about **$0.40** in total. Hosting during the beta is expected to stay within Google Cloud's free tiers.

What it does well

Examples from the simulated conversations, each checked against the live pages.

● CORRECT · DEGREE PLANNING

Student: **hey im a freshman in CS, what classes should i be taking my first semester?**

> As a first-year CS student starting with CS 1400 and Precalculus, the Kahlert School's suggested plan for fall looks like this: CS 1400 (4 credits), MATH 1080 (5 credits), two Gen Ed courses (3 credits each). That totals 15 credits.…
>
> Before you register, confirm your math placement and course plan with a CS academic advisor…

Courses and credits match the official CS 4-year plan it linked, it mentions the other starting track, and it sends the student to an advisor.

● CORRECT · GRADUATE ADMISSIONS

Student: **I'm looking at the MS in mechanical engineering. What are the admission requirements and when is the deadline for fall 2027?**

> …a priority deadline of January 1, 2027 (the date for fall funding consideration) and a final deadline of May 1, 2027.… Undergraduate GPA of at least 3.0 on a 4.0 scale. GRE General Test is optional.…

Every date, requirement and code matches the department's deadlines page, which it read live.

● HONEST ABOUT A GAP

Student: **How big are the engineering classes at the U usually? I don't want to be in a 300 person lecture all the time**

> I couldn't find published class-size numbers for the college, so I can't tell you the typical lecture size. The closest figure is on the ECE Prospective Students page, which lists a faculty-to-undergraduate ratio of 1:8. That's an overall ratio, not a class size, and the page was last updated in 2021…

No invented numbers. It gives the nearest real figure with its date and points to the advisers and the college office.

● STAYS ON TOPIC

Student: **can u check my statics hw answer? its ME EN 2010, a 200 N force at 30 degrees on a 2 m beam…**

> I'm scoped to University of Utah questions, so I can't solve or write coursework, code or essays. If you're stuck on a class, the college's Tutoring Resources page lists TA hours, department tutoring and other help.

Declined in 1.2 seconds for $0.0001, with a pointer to tutoring.

Known limitations, and how we'll handle them

Severity: **high** means a student could make a wrong decision from the answer; **medium** means confusing but unlikely to cause harm; **low** means cosmetic. None of the errors involved personal data or unsafe content.

What we saw	Severity	Example	Why it happens	How we'll fix it
Misses a department's own policy page and answers from a secondary page	HIGH	Said there's no minimum GPA to switch into Mechanical Engineering. The department's page requires 2.500.	Search ranks flowcharts and transfer pages above the policy page.	Rank policy pages and handbook sections higher; treat "GPA", "repeat" and "full major" as policy questions. Regression questions added.
Outdated or wrong advisor names	HIGH	Named a graduate advisor to an undergraduate, from an old copy of the college's advisor directory.	The directory moved and the old copy stayed in the index; its undergraduate and graduate sections were merged into one list.	Drop pages that now redirect during the weekly check; keep section headings when reading pages; prefer the department's own advising page.
Doesn't know information on central university sites	HIGH	Couldn't confirm the WUE tuition discount for a Colorado student, or which AP Computer Science score earns CS 1400 and 1410.	Only the college and department sites are indexed.	Add a short list of central pages: admissions, tuition, WUE, AP credit, the Registrar's calendar, first-generation support.

What we saw	Severity	Example	Why it happens	How we'll fix it
Misses details inside long documents, or reports only one side of a conflict	HIGH	Said there's no deadline to join a research lab, though the BME handbook sets one (junior-year winter break). Missed the engineering tuition surcharge on page 2 of the tuition table.	Long PDFs are split by page, not by section, so the right passage isn't found.	Split handbooks by section heading; tell the bot to state both versions when sources disagree and send the student to an advisor.
Events and dates not on the calendar	MEDIUM	Missed Engineering Day (Saturday, November 14) when a parent asked what's on that week. Gave one wrong weekday.	Engineering Day isn't on the events calendar, and older news posts outrank its page.	Ask the college to add it to the calendar; rank the current event page above old news; give the bot dates with their weekday.
Slips in long conversations	MEDIUM	Referred to resources "I listed earlier" that it never listed; switched a student's CS plan track mid-conversation.	Follow-up searches lose names and details from earlier turns.	Carry earlier turns' key details into follow-up searches; add a rule against referring to things not said.
Links and link labels	LOW	3 of 209 cited links were broken: 1 made up by the bot, 2 copied from dead links on college pages. Some link labels didn't match their page.	The bot sometimes names a resource from memory and attaches the nearest link.	Check every link against the pages it actually read before sending the answer.
"Which major should I choose?" lists everything first	LOW	Listed all majors without asking about the student's interests. With interests given, it narrowed well.	No instruction for this kind of question.	Give a short overview, then ask what the student enjoys; test with new questions.

Two examples of high-severity errors

INCORRECT · DEPARTMENT POLICY

Student: **is there a minimum gpa to switch into mech? mine is like a 2.6**

> I didn't find a minimum GPA to declare mechanical engineering as a current U student.…

The department's future-students page requires a 2.500 University of Utah GPA to change into Mechanical Engineering, plus a meeting with an ME advisor, so this student qualifies. The bot answered from the policy and transfer pages instead, though it did send the student to an advisor.

INCORRECT · EVENTS

Student: **Is there anything else going on at the engineering college the week of Nov 9 that a high schooler could come see?**

> …The college's Engineering Day, which offers lab tours and hands-on demos, has run in past years, but I didn't find a 2026 date…

Engineering Day is Saturday, November 14, 2026, for high school students and parents. It isn't on the events calendar. Asked directly in another conversation, the bot found it.

Problems found on the college's websites

Checking answers against the live pages turned up content problems that affect students whether or not they use the assistant. Each was confirmed on the page on October 21.

Where	Problem	Suggested owner
price.utah.edu/scholarships and /financial-aid	The scholarship deadline appears as both February 1 and February 8. The scholarships page was updated October 19 with February 1, but older sections and the financial aid page still say February 8.	College scholarships office
College events calendar	The calendar's fall 2026 "last day to withdraw" dates are two weeks earlier than the Registrar's: October 30 vs. November 13 for full-semester classes, and November 13 vs. November 27 for second-half classes. The Registrar's calendar is the official one.	College calendar editor, with the Registrar
College events calendar	Engineering Day (Saturday, November 14, 2026) isn't on the calendar.	Outreach / events
Majors, Future Students and Outreach pages	The "Which Engineering Major Should I Choose?" PDF link returns "not found".	Web team
Engineering Floor page	The housing application link (housing.utah.edu/applications) returns "not found".	Web team
Chemical Engineering handbook 2025–26	The 4-year and 5-year plans are images only, so screen readers and search can't read them. The repeat-course rule says three attempts on page 10 and two attempts (third with approval) on page 23.	Chemical Engineering advising

Where	Problem	Suggested owner
price.utah.edu/student-organizations-dnu	A 2018 student organizations page is still public and comes up in searches.	Web team

Next steps

Fix and re-measure

- Fix the four high-severity patterns above (about one to two weeks of work).
- Run the same 96 questions again and publish a before/after comparison, listing every question that changed.
- Turn real beta questions into new test questions each week.

A wider beta

- 20 to 40 testers: ambassadors, current students and two or three advisors, behind the password.
- Review every thumbs-down weekly; refresh the site content weekly.
- Pause the beta if a tester reports acting on a wrong deadline or requirement.

Human review

- Two or three advisors rate about 50 real beta answers as pass or fail on: correct, actionable, right referral, and the linked page supports the claim.
- A quarter of answers rated by two people, to check that raters agree.

Approvals needed before any public launch

- University Counseling Center: the crisis response wording.
- Privacy Office: saving conversations for 90 days.
- UIT or college IT: hosting, and who maintains it after the pilot.
- Web team and Marketing & Communications: putting it on price.utah.edu.

Method notes

How answers are graded

A question can have up to four checks. *Cited:* the answer links one of the pages that contain the answer. *Facts:* it includes each required fact; each fact accepts a few phrasings copied from the page. *Forbidden:* it doesn't make a known wrong statement. *Declined* or *not declined:* it refuses exactly when it should. An answer passes when every check passes. Network or service errors are logged separately and never counted as wrong answers; there were none in this run.

The likely ranges

Ranges are 95% Wilson score intervals, which stay honest for small numbers of questions. For example, 9 of 10 has a range of 60–98%, so small groups should be read as rough.

Results by check (all 96 questions, 192 answers)

Check	Passed
Linked an expected page	`121 of 142`
Included the required facts	`116 of 154`
Avoided known wrong statements	`42 of 44`
Declined when it should	`24 of 24`
Answered when it should	`22 of 22`
Named an event really on the calendar	`4 of 4`

Reproducing these numbers

From the project repository: `python -m evals.run answers --reps 2` for the question set, `python -m evals.run baseline` for the search comparison, and `python -m evals.converse` for conversation testing. Each run saves its answers and a summary under `evals/results/`.

Price Engineering Assistant is a student proof of concept and not an official University of Utah service. Results describe the beta as of October 21, 2026.